

Making Sense of Serving Sizes

During recovery from an eating disorder, it can be difficult to relearn how to eat in a normal, and non-disordered way. One of the challenges is figuring out how much of the different types of food groups is enough. This is a starting guide to help you on your way.

Six Main Food Groups

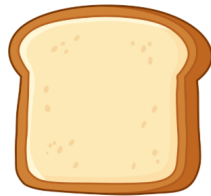
There are six main food groups and ideally we should have a little from each of these groups every day. Some days we might have a little more than the recommended amount, other days a little less. Below are guidelines that indicate the *minimum recommended daily serves* of each food group. Remember that the amount each person requires will vary based on their age, gender, level of activity, height, weight, build etc.

The amount of food you need will also depend on what's going on with your eating disorder and what stage of treatment you're at. For example, if you are underweight and need to regain weight in order to become physically and mentally healthy, you will need to eat a little more than usual for a while.

Grains

The recommended intake is 5-6 serves per day for women, 6-7 per day for men. Some examples of 1 serve in this food group include:

- 1 slice of bread or ½ a bread roll
- ¼ cup of muesli
- ½ cup cooked porridge
- ½ cup cooked pasta or rice
- ¾ cup flaky cereal
- 1 medium potato



Protein

The recommended intake is 2-3 serves per day. Some examples of 1 serve in this food group include:

- A palm sized pieces of raw meat or chicken (100g)
- A hand sized piece of raw fish (120g)
- Small can of fish e.g., salmon or tuna
- 2 large eggs
- 1 cup of cooked or canned legumes
- 170g of tofu
- A small handful of nuts or seeds (30g)



Fats

The recommended intake is 1-2 serves per day for men and women. Some examples of 1 serve in this food group include:

- 1 tablespoon of margarine, oil, butter, cream etc.
- 1 teaspoon of mayonnaise
- ¼ avocado (small)
- 5 small olives



Vegetables

The recommended intake is 5+ serves per day. Some examples of 1 serve in this food group include:

- ½ cup cooked vegetables
- ½ cup cooked or canned legumes
- ½ corn cob
- ½ cup baked beans
- 1 cup leafy greens
- 1 large carrot
- 1 cup broccoli
- 1 small tomato



Fruit

The recommended intake is 2 serves per day. Some examples of 1 serve in this food group include:

- 1 medium piece of fresh fruit (e.g., apple, pear, banana)
- 2 small pieces (e.g., apricots, kiwi fruit)
- 1 cup of berries
- 1 cup fruit salad or canned fruit
- 4 dried apricots or 2 tablespoons of sultanas
- ½ cup fruit juice



Dairy & Alternatives

The recommended intake is 3 serves per day. Some examples of 1 serve in this group are:

- 1 cup milk or soy milk (250ml)
- 1 tub (200g) yoghurt
- 1 cup of custard
- 2 slices (40g) of cheese



Fun Foods

Some foods don't fit neatly into any particular food group, but can still be enjoyed as part of a balanced, flexible diet. Remember, eating isn't just to fuel the body, it's also about enjoyment, celebration, and pleasure!

- 1 ice cream on a stick (or 2 small scoops)
- 1 doughnut or 1 slice of cake
- 1 small cup of hot chips
- 1 fun size bag of potato chips
- 5 or 6 lollies
- A row of chocolate (4 squares)



Please remember, this information is general in nature and does not replace individual advice from a dietitian. If you're still unsure about what or how much you should be eating each day, we recommend consulting with a dietitian; preferably one who has experience working with eating disorders.